

HANDSTAND VARIATIONS

Handstands Progression – Page 1, Column 1

INTRODUCTION

Several books could be written on handstands alone. The information presented here is condensed and will focus only on the most important points of each technique. Many of the finer details are so physical, so individual, so movement or balance related, they cannot be understood simply through written words. A good coach with hands-on experience trumps all.

It is important to maintain proper technique while performing any type of handstand, and not just for aesthetics. Proper handstand technique stacks all of your joints in alignment and reduces the amount of muscular effort required to perform the movement. This makes the handstand significantly easier, and also improves body awareness and positioning for other skills you will learn in bodyweight training.

In the same way that the squat is foundational to human movement, handstands are one of the fundamental positions in bodyweight training. If your execution of an unweighted or air squat is lacking, you will likely not be able to execute loaded techniques like front squats, weighted back squats, overhead squats, and Olympic lifts. Without a solid foundation in the squat, all of your other exercises will fail to develop correctly. Proper handstands carry the same effect with many other bodyweight training techniques.

The handstand is the one skill that should be trained almost every day if you desire to become proficient in bodyweight training. Certain variations like the wall handstand make it very easy to log quality skill work without jeopardizing rest and recovery. Constant practice and refinement of handstand technique will yield consistent rewards in the future.

Note that performance on skill-based movements will typically fall into a bell curve based on consistency and progression. For example, when you begin practicing handstands you will normally fail all the time—then, as you improve, you will begin achieving two-second holds here and there. Further improvement will lead to consistent two-second holds, as well as occasional holds of around nine seconds. From this we can conclude two things:

1. The length of holds falls in the middle of the bell curve where your most consistent performance lies. This means that your abilities are best summed up by your consistent attempts. The median or average of your holds defines your ability.
2. There are outliers where you tend to do better or worse than your regular performance.

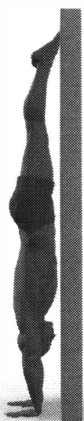
Do not focus on the outliers. When it comes to practicing skills, the key is to make them consistent. Raise the consistency of your holds by aiming toward the goal of performing the skill well all the time. In a sample group of ten handstand holds, you may perform zero seconds once, two seconds once, four seconds six times, eight seconds once, and ten seconds once. Your goal is to focus on obtaining the four-second range consistently and then improving upon it, rather than aiming for ten seconds all the time with mixed results. The human condition is to focus on the best (and post videos of it to YouTube or Instagram) and push the worst out of the mind. Instead, focus on becoming consistent. Consistency is key to developing greater static and dynamic body awareness. If you become fatigued and inconsistent in your holds, take a break. Don't push yourself too hard for that one ten-second hold, because that is not as important as overall consistency.

Additionally, it is imperative to minimize the roll out or pirouette fall as you exit the handstand position. Falling over in any handstand position tends to reinforce bad habits. It tells your body, "When I hit the point where I cannot hold a stable handstand, I need to bail out." Instead you should be fighting for every inch and every position, especially when you are learning. You obviously want to emphasize form, but if you do not learn how to fight for the handstand position you (1) do not build the strength-stability in your muscles to fight for it, and (2) you teach yourself bad habits.

To summarize, here are the concepts to focus on for handstands:

- If possible, work on handstands almost every day.
- Emphasize correct body positioning at all times.
- Focus on overall consistency.
- Form is the priority, but always fight for the handstand instead of bailing.
- Practice does not make perfect; perfect practice makes perfect.

You may encounter psychological issues with maintaining focus or fighting frustration if your holds aren't where you'd like them to be. If this occurs, step back, take a rest break, and calm yourself by practicing deep breathing (in through your nose, out through your mouth). This will slow your heart rate and increase concentration. Take time to visualize the movement in your mind before attempting it again once you are calm and rested. This practice can be used for any type of skill work, not just handstands.



WALL HANDSTAND – LEVELS 1-4

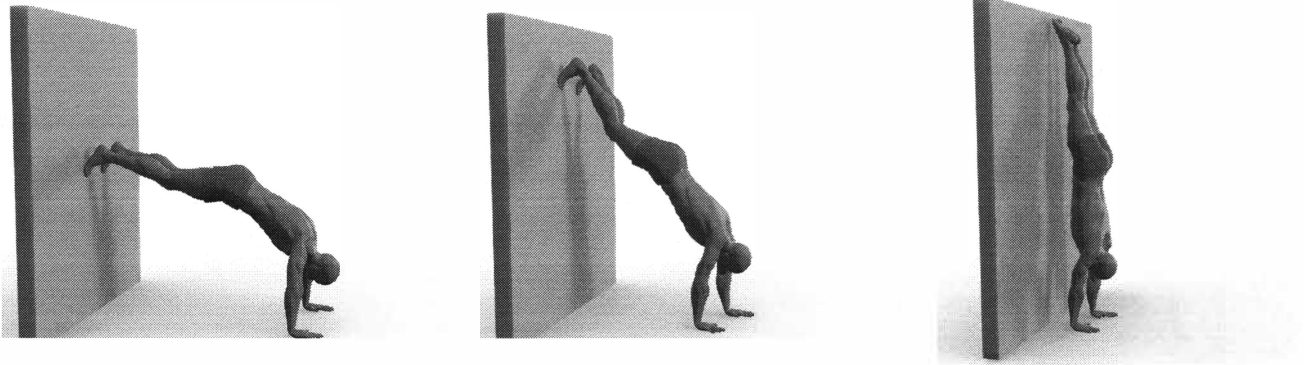
Handstands are a critical component of bodyweight training, as they lay a solid foundation for all gymnastics moves and many bodyweight movements. It is important to properly develop this movement, which is why it is first in the skill category. Wall handstands (which can be abbreviated *Wall HS*) are a category all to themselves for the first four difficulty levels. Wall handstands should be performed with the following technique notes in mind:

- Hands shoulder-width apart. This is important in the long run for handstand pushups, so do not get in the habit of hands wide when starting.
- Stomach to the wall.
- Hands as close to the wall as possible without tipping over. Your wrists will typically be two to six inches from the wall, depending on the width of your body.
- Arms locked straight.
- Pushed tall as much as possible. Your shoulders should be pushed as far away from your hands as possible, with your shoulder blades elevated. (Your shoulders should effectively be earmuffs with your armpits facing as far out as possible.)
- Thoracic spine fully extended. Your chest should be upright, which should generate some tension through the abdominals.
- Pelvis slightly posteriorly rotated. While your lower back is naturally curved in extension when standing, this should be gently reversed when you are in the handstand position. To cue this motion, squeeze your glutes slightly and simultaneously maintain tension on your abdominals (trying to bring your belly button back toward your spine). This should help eliminate the arch, a common error seen in handstand practice.
- Legs oriented neutrally so that they are in line with the rest of your body from all angles. There is a small amount of leeway here; our hips may need to bend in order for your toes to touch the wall. The closer to the wall your hands are placed, the less this will happen.
- Knees locked straight, with your toes pointed in order to keep your body tight. You can squeeze your legs together in order to generate tension and maintain proper handstand posture.
- Your scapulas should be fully elevated. At the height of elevation, retract them slightly in order to stabilize them.

All of these body cues summarize the ideal position for a handstand: a straight line with no bending anywhere in the body. Since your body is going to be a rigid like a plank of wood, small movements will control the portion that is in the air. Your forearms and hands (which are on the floor) will perform all of these small movements. To allow for the greatest amount of control, spread your fingers out as far as possible and exert pressure through your fingertips in order to maintain balance. Hand positioning against the floor will be further addressed in the grip section.

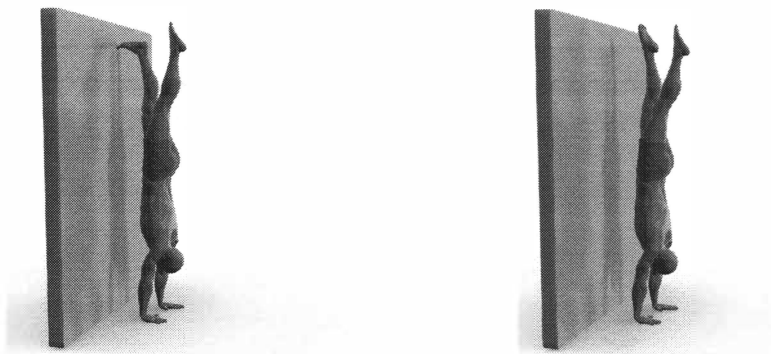
As you can imagine, using only your wrists to control a handstand will be difficult initially. New athletes who are learning the handstand will often use their shoulders and hips to change their body shape and

balance a handstand. This will cause their shoulders to come out of alignment with their head and the rest of their body, and their feet will move around a lot while in the air. Resist this temptation—it will instill bad habits that are hard to break. A proper handstand held for a minute or longer should primarily work your forearms (if you have the requisite strength). The rest of your body should be relatively unused except maybe some endurance burn in your shoulders.



The sequence above illustrates the technique to move into the stomach-to-wall wall handstand. Begin in a pushup position and slowly walk your legs up the wall while you simultaneously walk your hands closer to the wall. Keep your body straight and do not arch your back (doing so will force you out of the position via a forward roll or pirouette). If you are new to wall handstands, you may not be ready to perform this to the full extent that your stomach is against the wall. Only go as far as you are comfortable. If you are a beginner, you should only touch the wall with the tips of your toes. Over time, you will feel more at ease with this exercise and can conquer your fears by moving your stomach closer to the wall.

Once you become proficient with wall handstands, there will come a time where you barely push your toes off the wall. You will use your wrists to correct the overbalance by digging down with your fingers. This will keep you from tipping over. Avoid arching your lower back in order to compensate for when you push your toes off. Any adjustments should be made with your wrists.

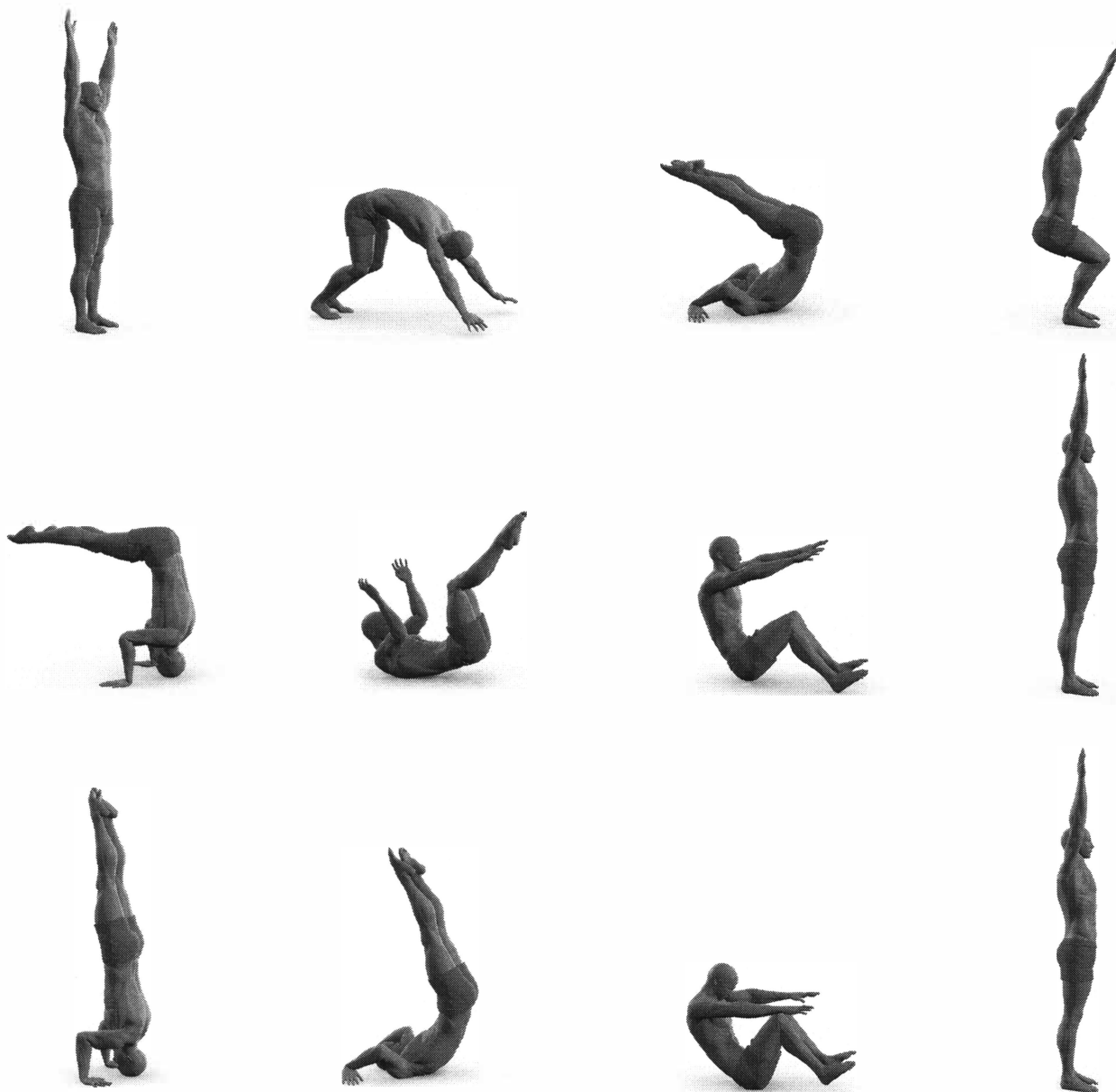


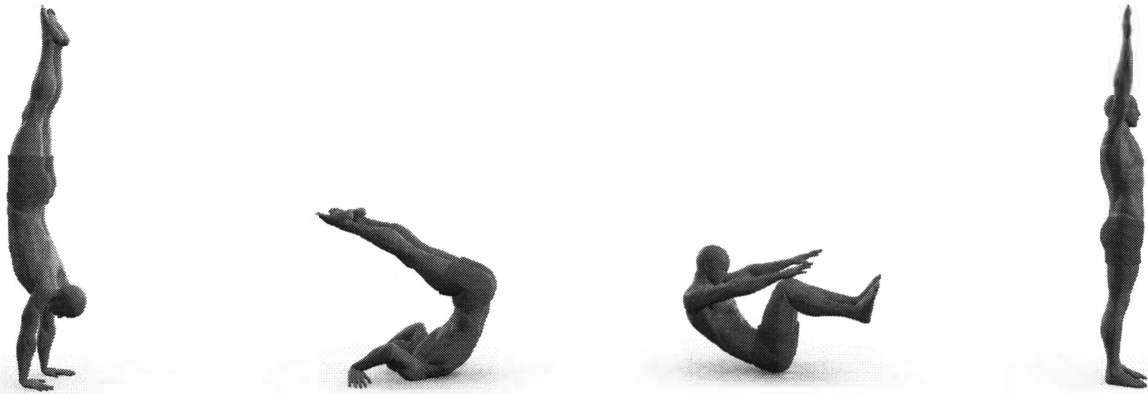
You can also push off from a handstand with split feet (shown above). To do this, begin with a balanced handstand position and split your feet apart with one foot remaining on the wall. Next, slowly move your remaining foot off the wall, bringing both feet together while maintaining balance. Hold this position for as long as possible.

As you become more proficient with this, you will be able to balance with both feet away from the wall for longer and longer periods. When you can hold this position for fifteen to twenty seconds, split your handstand workout into two parts: 1) kick up to freestanding handstands and 2) continue to work on your balance with freestanding wall handstands. Once you can consistently hold the position for thirty seconds or more (while maintaining proper balance with your body straight), it is time to solely focus on your freestanding kick to handstand movement.

Rolling Out and Pirouetting

There are two basic techniques to suddenly end (bail from) a handstand: rolling out and pirouetting. Rolling out is the best method if you are working against the wall—it correlates better to maintaining body positions. Using the pirouette movement to bail from a handstand as a beginner can lead to the development of bad habits. Stick with the roll out.



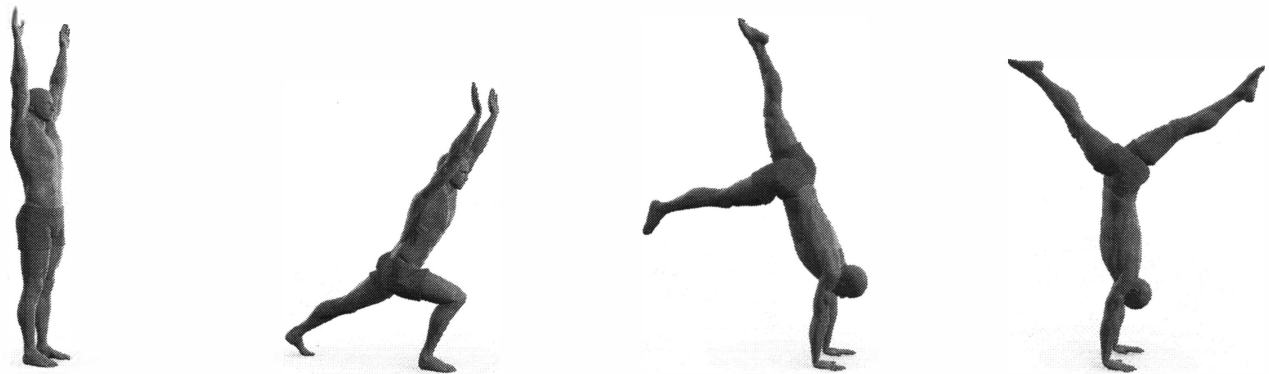


Rolling out of a handstand is an extension of the forward roll on the ground. If you are not proficient in the forward roll you should first practice it on a soft mat or grass. Apply pressure through your hands such that when you tuck your chin to your chest you will be able to put your weight on the back of your neck and roll smoothly out of a movement.

Working from the handstand position, bend your arms slowly so that you lower toward the ground in a controlled manner. From there, tuck your chin to your neck and curl your body into a fetal position as you allow gravity to move you through the roll. Above are some sequences you can practice to become more proficient in rolling out.

If you are unsure of how to do this correctly or fearful of rolling out from the handstand position, there are two options. The first option, which is preferred, is to ask for help from a spotter. They can hold your legs or ankles up and help you execute the roll in slow motion until you feel more comfortable. The other option is to learn how to pirouette out of a movement by twisting your body.

Kicking Up



The *lunge to handstand* (shown above) is often performed improperly. To get a sense of how much force is needed when kicking up to a handstand, start by practicing against the wall with your back to the wall. Make sure the movements are as consistent as possible. Mechanically, here is a set of instructions that beginners should follow:

- First, you want to take the handstand position upright: straight body, standing with your arms overhead. This makes the kick up to a handstand much easier because you keep your body in alignment

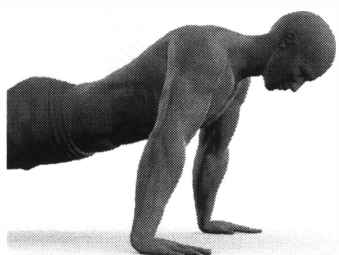
throughout the entire motion. Without this setup, your body will not be tight and will therefore not be controlled while you perform the movement. You should go into the movement with your legs together, arms overhead, shoulders “in” your ears, chest up, and core/shoulders tight.

- During the motion of kicking up to a handstand, the only part of the setup that will change is you will lunge with your leg—this is the hinge on which your body will rotate while remaining straight. The reason you move your lunging leg out of alignment is so you do not compromise the straight-body, arms overhead position you previously set up.
- Place your lunging leg approximately half of your height in front of you. Shift your weight onto that leg as you begin to tilt your upper body down for the kick up to a handstand. Your hands should lead the way. Be sure to keep the knee of your lunging leg as straight as possible to maintain proper tension in your hamstrings. Once your hands hit the ground, dig in with your fingertips to stabilize the handstand as you kick up. Use the tension in your hamstrings to kick up your lunging leg.
- At this point your legs should be together—in the air, above you—in a perfect straight-body position. If anything came out of alignment during the movement (such as your legs spreading apart), appropriate compensation will be necessary. Things like this will happen while you are learning. One way to determine what you did wrong is taking a video of yourself performing the movement, or you can have someone who has mastered it watch you and coach you in the right direction.

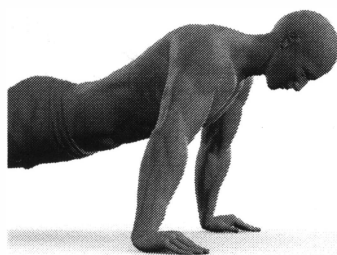
If you can execute the lunge to handstand correctly, you are in good shape. From there, all you have to do is exert the force necessary to hit the correct position during the kick up and be sure to apply the pressure from your fingertips. You may find it useful to use a wall at first to figure out how much you power should be in your kick. Once you become proficient at kicking up, you should feel like you can lock into a perfect handstand at the top of the movement without wobbling.

Note that the *back to the wall handstand* is a technique that can be used to teach a proper handstand. This is especially helpful if you lack the strength or technique to bail out of a handstand with your stomach to the wall. If you do use this technique, try to phase it out as soon as possible.

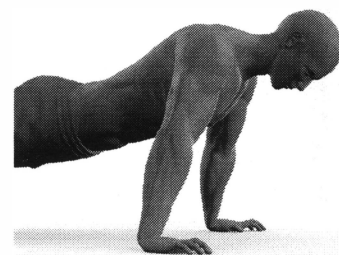
Grip



Flat Hand



Arched Hand



Cambered Hand

There are a few different ways to grip the ground: flat hand, arched hand, or cambered hand. There is nothing wrong with the flat and arched hand positions, but if you are working toward high-level handstand movements you should use the cambered hand position. This hand position allows you to generate more tension in your hand, enabling stronger, more precise corrections that are useful for advanced movements.

- The flat-hand grip is pretty straightforward—your whole hand is flat against the ground. It can be hard to balance a handstand with this grip, as you do so with your palms and fingertips.
- The arched-hand grip (or dome hand) puts only your fingertips and the heel of your hand in contact with the ground. This allows for full handstand balance much easier.
- The cambered-hand grip is a bit different. You begin by placing your palm in contact with the ground, then curling your fingertips in a manner that a dome is created, but only from your fingertips, as your entire palm remains in contact with the ground. This grip gives your hand three points of ground contact: fingertips, top of palm, and heel of palm. For an excellent analysis of this grip, visit the website of physical therapist Shon Grosse: <http://shongrosse.com/2011/08/the-cambered-hand-pushup/>

If you are falling forward, dig your fingertips into the ground. If you are falling over backward, distribute your weight through your palms. The additional control from the cambered hand grip may help those of you who are having problems with balance in the skill. Note that getting used to the new position may require some practice.

HEADSTAND – LEVEL N/A

This movement is not on the charts, but is important to recognize. While it has its uses, the same body positions can be built more thoroughly by performing a correct wall handstand. Headstands place an enormous amount of pressure on the neck. It is not a recommended position for beginners and is best performed under a coach's supervision.

If you decide to perform headstands anyway, here are a few things to know: Body positioning is the same as for a handstand, except for how you set up the movement. With a headstand, weight is placed on your head and hands in a tripod position. This means you can draw a triangle on the ground and place your head and hands at each of the three points. You can then use your head and the handstand position to keep your center of mass between those points as you move your legs overhead.

FREESTANDING HANDSTAND – LEVEL 5

A *freestanding handstand* (which can be abbreviated *Free HS*) is essentially a wall handstand without the wall. All of the same techniques used to perform a wall handstand apply. Because wall handstands are easier, most beginner athletes start there and work up to freestanding handstands.



Scapular Positioning: Your scapulas should be fully elevated. At the height of elevation, retract them slightly for stability.

If you walk into any gymnastics gym and tell every person present to kick up to a handstand and hold it, here is what you will see: Those with the best handstands are the most skilled overall, while those with the worst handstands are the least skilled overall. Handstands are one of the most fundamental movements in gymnastics and in bodyweight training as well. It is critical to become proficient in them, as it will make flipping, twisting, and other body movements that occur between being upright and being inverted much easier to execute. They provide an overview of an athlete's proprioceptive and kinesthetic awareness in the inverted position, which is counter-intuitive to normal body positioning. In a word: they are a critical skill to acquire.

Develop the freestanding handstand position on the floor, then move to parallettes and rings as you become more proficient. Rings handstands and one-arm handstands will be the true test of your handstand abilities long-term. It is actually easier to perform handstands on the parallettes (because it is easier to obtain a better grip), but it is safer to begin on the floor, especially if you have just progressed from wall handstands to freestanding handstands. If you still need to work on kicking up, bail techniques, and/or grip, you should read through the previous section.

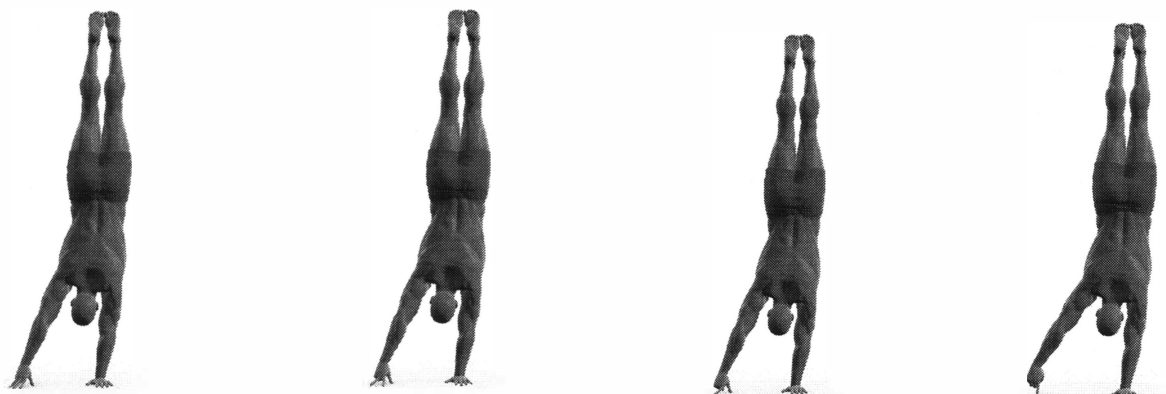
You should seek to reduce wobbling in both the dynamic and static senses. For the dynamic motion, you want to be able to kick straight up to a handstand without wobbling at all. It takes a lot of practice to learn proper control, as kick-up force is hard to modulate. You do not want to under-balance and come back down; nor do you want to overbalance and be forced to compensate by arching your back or walking on your hands. For the static motion, obtain a solid handstand position so that you only have to make a few corrections using your wrists. This level of superior control will look good to any observers, and it requires far less energy than wobbling back and forth.

Once you have developed the position through wall handstand training and become proficient in it, all it takes to achieve a freestanding handstand is consistent practice. Practice every day if you are able. This skill is

an A-list skill in the Gymnastics Code of Points. If you need additional information or further visualization, here are some additional resources:

- Valentin Uzunov's "The Handstand: a four-stage training model" – <http://docslide.us/documents/the-handstand-a-four-stage-training-model.html>
- GMB's handstand tutorial – <http://gmb.io/handstand>
- Natalie Reckerts's handstand tutorial – <http://youtube.com/watch?v=Lz7a6eOb4Hs>
- Antranik's comprehensive handstand tutorial – <http://antranik.org/comprehensive-handstand-tutorial>

FREESTANDING HANDSTAND WITH ONE-ARM SUPPORT – LEVELS 6-9



In the images above, you will find four variations of a freestanding handstand that you can use to work toward a one-arm handstand. All of these variations involve balancing with one hand and some of the fingers on your other hand (each variation uses a different number of fingers). From left to right: *Free HS with 4 Fingers* (Level 6), *Free HS with 3 Fingers* (Level 7), *Free HS with 2 Fingers* (Level 8), and *Free HS with 1 Finger* (Level 9).

Using a wall to assist with one-arm handstands is not effective. There are many photos online of one-arm handstands against a wall. While it makes a cute photo, using the wall does little to help develop the skill sets required for a true one-armed handstand. However, the wall can be useful for building up the necessary strength and conditioning, especially in your shoulders and wrists. These bear the brunt of the pressure but do not help much with balance, which is the foundation that the one-arm handstand is built upon.

Before you begin learning the one-arm handstand, you must develop a solid, straight-body handstand. The variation used to develop a one-arm handstand is a freestanding straddled handstand with a slow, progressive weight shift to one side. Use the straddled handstand because straddling your legs lowers your center of gravity, which makes the skill much easier to perform. With your legs spread, leverage to both sides is increased, making it more difficult for the body to sway in either direction. This gives stability. As you gain experience, challenge yourself by closing your legs.

The straddle handstand requires the ability to perform a solid handstand because your core is more apt to be unstable in this position, and you need the tight body position to learn correct balance at the wrists. Finding the correct center of balance in your hands is critical to learning this skill. You can reduce assistance in the straddled handstand by slowly removing fingers from the skill. First to go is the pinky. Follow that with the ring finger and continue until the thumb (and therefore the entire hand) is no longer helping.

Since balance at the wrists is critical to learning the skill, increased grip strength will significantly speed up its development. The center of balance of the one-arm handstand is somewhere near the joint of the ring finger (depending on one's anthropometry), so strengthening the whole grip is fine but you will see better results from specifically strengthening the last three fingers of each hand.

Advanced handstands of all kinds should be practiced either on a hard floor or hand balancing implements. It is much easier to maintain control with fingertips that are being pressed into a solid floor, or hands that are squeezing very strongly on implements or parallettes.

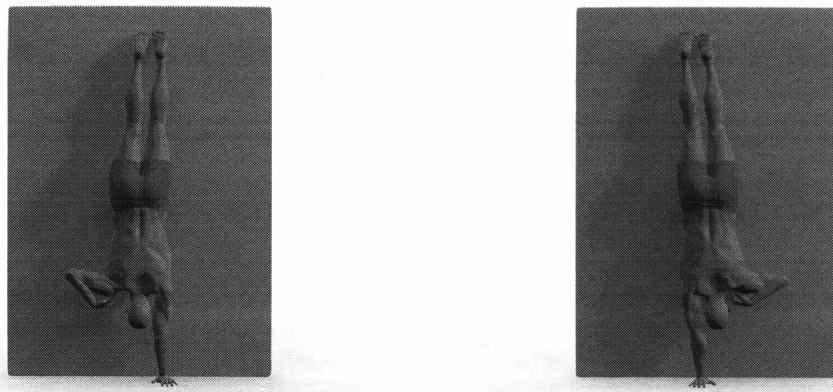
The key for the one-arm handstand is exactly like the freestanding handstand, except after you balance the straddle handstand, you should lock your shoulder in the active position (shoulder earmuff) and slowly shift your weight onto one arm. Since you are shifting your weight, the weight on your other arm will decrease and may cause you to come up on your fingertips on that hand. This is totally fine. Over time you will decrease the amount of the hand you use.

If you feel yourself wobbling throughout your body as your weight shifts to a one-arm hold, keep practicing. Remember, the critical component of learning a one-arm handstand is balancing the movement directly through your wrists. If your body is wobbling through your core or legs, you are not learning correct balance patterns, and are making the movement harder than it needs to be.

As you lean over, you will notice that the center of gravity in your hand will shift as well: toward the joint of your first ring finger. This progression of weight shifting in your planted hand is normal, so get used to the way it feels. You can supplement with specific grip work as well. Your ring and pinky fingers will strain to keep your balance centered in this small area, so it is important to take care of your joints. It is normal for one of your joints to get noticeably sore while practicing this movement. If this soreness does not dissipate naturally, take a break for a couple of days to allow your tissues to heal. This will prevent overuse injuries.

Yuri Marmerstein, a self-taught professional acrobat based in Las Vegas, consented to write the one-arm handstand section of *Overcoming Gravity*, found later in this chapter. You will find that he builds on the basics given here.

FREESTANDING HANDSTAND SHOULDER TAPS – LEVEL N/A

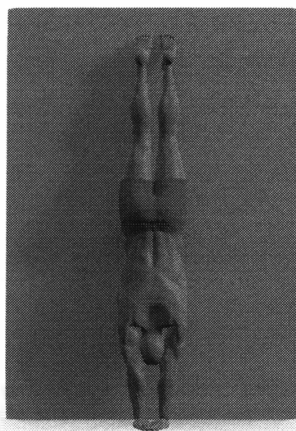


Freestanding handstand shoulder taps (which can be abbreviated *Free HS Shld Taps*) are not included on the charts, but this would be the position where they would appear. Free HS Shld Taps are a dynamic and intermediate balance skill. The goal of this skill is to balance from side to side and release your opposing hand at each juncture. This can serve as an excellent conditioning exercise and give you a good feel for dynamic stability in one-arm positions while maintaining adequate body tension.

These can be performed against a wall as conditioning for handstands, but proper care must be taken not to break form, close the shoulder angle, or arch your back. This skill is a critical component of learning the one-arm handstand. It is also a very good supplement in learning dynamic awareness, especially if you need to improve your handstand body position mechanics or want to do handstand walking for distance in the future.

HANDSTAND WALKING – LEVEL N/A

Handstand walking is another good supplement for learning the one-arm handstand. Maintaining a correct tight-body technique is critical for learning this skill. If you have been able to advance this far, you should be ready to execute handstand walking without arching your handstand. This dynamic stability will help in your weight shift, which will ultimately help your one-arm handstand.

HANDS-CLOSE-TOGETHER HANDSTAND – LEVEL N/A

This is another variation you can utilize as you work toward the one-arm handstand. While performing this skill, you progressively move your hands closer together and begin biasing your weight onto one arm. Eventually, this will yield a handstand where one arm is on top of the other, and can be slowly lifted off so to bring you to a one-arm handstand position. This exercise is not as measurable as other variations, so it is not effective for training, but it does make a good supplemental exercise.

ONE-ARM HANDSTAND – LEVEL 10



Yuri Marmerstein is a self-taught professional acrobat based in Las Vegas. He is lending his expertise for this section.

“The one-arm handstand is an immensely complicated skill. It takes a lot of effort, perseverance, and dedication to learn compared to a traditional handstand. Realistically you can expect to train five to six days per week for a couple of years to achieve the balance and precision required for this skill.

Balance is all about making movements to maintain your center of gravity over your base of support. In essence, to stand is to continually save yourself from falling. On two arms, you can basically only fall in two directions—forward or backward. This makes the corrections pretty simple. However, on one arm, you have half the base of support and must now balance along both your sagittal and longitudinal axes. This means you can fall in any direction along 360 degrees of your hand. On top of this, there is a greater shoulder strength and stability requirement, in addition to body control and awareness. That is without mentioning the control required to keep your body from rotating while you are balancing on one arm.

I do not want to put anyone off, but I do want to be realistic. There is a reason why many people only dream of this skill and never achieve it. It is not something you can mess around with once a week and expect to master it. To make it work, you have to be a little bit obsessed.

Still interested?

Here are a few prerequisites you need to achieve before attempting a one-arm handstand:

- A minimum of sixty seconds freestanding balance on two arms. This is a bare minimum and it should be consistently achievable, not just a PR. The handstand in question should balance with minimal visible movement of the body. It will also be particularly helpful if it is in good alignment, meaning the body is stacked over the hands so that minimal strength is required to hold the position. It is possible to do a one-arm handstand without good alignment, but it is much more difficult.
- The next step toward mastery of the two-arm handstand is movement. This means you can change the position in a controlled manner while maintaining balance. Changing position can involve movement of the head, shoulders, legs, back, and anything else you can think of. You can start by isolating one joint at a time, then move on to multiple joints at the same time.
- Additionally, it is good to get comfortable with several leg positions aside from straight-body. You especially want to become proficient in the tuck position, open straddle (legs aligned with your body), and the closed-hip straddle (legs slightly out of the vertical line but in a deeper split).
- Another concept along these lines is being able to break form and come back in line. This is very

important for awareness of alignment, as it will not be as obvious when you are on one arm. Breaking form can involve pinking at the hips, arching the back, closing the shoulders, and many other variations.

- Another idea that can be experimented with is rotation of the hips on two arms. Begin by twisting your legs from a left split to a right split, passing through a straddle. You can also experiment by rotating the hips in a tuck and a straight-body position to obtain a greater understanding of what it should feel like. Rotation of the body is a very important issue to deal with when shifting to one arm, and having awareness of the sensation is the first step to correcting it.
- A crucial element that is often overlooked is handstand walking. I actually spent the majority of my first year of hand balancing walking rather than standing. I do not think this is the ideal progression and I teach walking after static balance to my students. However, when I began learning the shift to one arm later on, there was not much issue with the actual shift aside from technical subtleties. I recently worked some one-arm progressions with a gentleman who had excellent balance on two arms but didn't spend much time walking on his hands. This made the act of shifting weight very awkward for him. Even though walking on the hands involves a mindless shifting of weight from one hand to the other without maintaining balance, those repetitions are still a considerable help once the time comes to work one-arm handstands. Apart from that, walking on your hands yields excellent strength and control.
- A press handstand from a seated position on the floor would be a minimum. Ideally, a press-to-handstand from a seated position should be achieved.
- As far as handstand pushups go, they will not have as much benefit for the one-arm handstand as straight-arm presses will, but they are very important for general upper-body strength. Even though they are not necessarily required, practicing basic one-arm balances like the crocodile and air baby will also help with your control and awareness in the one-arm handstand.
- The final prerequisite is proficiency in press handstands and handstand pushups. It is a good idea to be able to get to a handstand as many different ways as possible, but being able to get there using a controlled press is very beneficial for shoulder strength, active flexibility, and body awareness. Additionally, a handstand that is falling toward the heel of the hand can be saved by going into a press. The same goes for a handstand pushup. Though the one-arm handstand is by no means a strength move, it will be considerably easier to learn having acquired the combination of strength and flexibility required for a press.

Once you have the prerequisites down, you can begin to actually train for the one-arm handstand. The first order of business is the one-arm distribution (how you get to one arm). This is not as easy as it may seem. There are many techniques for shifting your weight to one arm. However, generally speaking, the less you think about it, the better. As a minimum requirement, the arm you are shifting the weight to must be vertical. Everything else is variable. An exception is brute strength, but that is not ideal.

I am going to first describe the easiest way to shift to one arm before I explain the others. Assuming that both arms are precisely shoulder width, they should both be completely vertical. You should also assume a decent open shoulder position in the handstand line. If both arms are already vertical, you don't have to do anything with the arm you are shifting to. Rather, move the rest of your body to maintain the position of your primary arm. If you try this in a pushup position you will notice the shoulder of the free arm actually tilts upward a little bit. Do not change anything about the arm you are shifting to; try to minimize as many

variables as possible. The tension will remain in your supporting arm, but should begin to relax as the weight shifts to your free arm. This will be very important when the time comes to lift your hand. Additionally, your head should remain in basically the same position during the shift.

How do you actually shift weight? The idea is to move your hips over the arm you are shifting toward. There are two other ways distinct ways to shift, but both can cause their own issues. Still, it is worth experimenting both of them, as you might like them.

- The first way to shift is the classic “ear to shoulder” style. This involves a strong elevation in your supporting arm, as well as your head moving closer to that side. It makes for a more upright and refined-looking one-arm handstand position, but it can make it more difficult to find the balance. It is also easy to shift too far to where your arm is no longer vertical.
- The second way to shift is the exact opposite of this, where your head moves away from your supporting arm to counterbalance your hips tilting far over the side. This technique is more common among athletes without formal acrobatic training. It is easier to find balance in this type of one-arm handstand position, but it requires more strength to hold.

A good general rule states that the more variables you can eliminate, the easier a movement will be. However, one common mistake is losing tension in your supporting shoulder during a shift. This will almost certainly cause a loss of balance.

It is easiest to begin the motion of shifting from a pushup position. Once you can perform this, the next step is to take the concept to a chest-to-wall handstand. The idea here is the same as in the pushup position. Shift your hips all the way above one hand. Maintain shoulder tension. Attempt to keep your hips square to the wall, as you do not want your hips to twist while you shift weight. Being aware of what that feels like is essential to learning the one-arm handstand. Remember, it is important to grasp the concept of weight-shifting prior to adding the balance.

To move to the next level, add the weight shift into your freestanding handstand. Start with slow, controlled movements—gradually shift your weight to one arm and feel your other arm get lighter. Practice both sides and keep your hands flat on the ground for now. The feeling you want to begin to develop is how to tense one arm while relaxing the other.

On the topic of leg positioning, I find it easier to learn one-arm handstands in a straddle position. It takes a good amount of hip flexibility to gain advantage from this, though. Additionally, it can be hard to maintain proper body tension with your legs apart. I have seen plenty of people who had an easier time learning a straight-body one-arm handstand first, even though the balance required for that position is more precise.

Apart from the movement required to shift your weight back and forth, the rest of your body should remain in one piece during this exercise. Try your best not to change your body position during the shift. Move everything over at once after the shift.

Once you feel that you can go far enough to one side, with control, the next stage is to release the palm of your free arm and come up on your fingertips. This will require more lean and a slight tilting of your body in the direction of your working arm in order to take more weight off your free arm. Remember to always keep your supporting arm vertical.

My recommendation once you can lift to the fingers of your free arm is to bend that arm at the elbow. This is not the only way, of course, but I find it a useful cue in relaxing your arm. Unnecessary tension in your free arm will make it more difficult to maintain balance while lifting your arm later on.

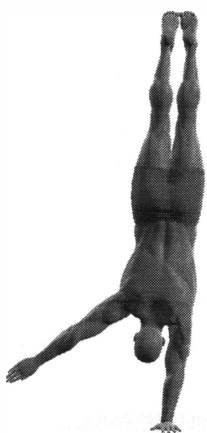
Balancing with your fingertips on your free arm is a long and frustrating stage. This is where the slackers are separated from the truly dedicated. Before moving on from here, my recommendation is to be able to hold at least thirty seconds consistently with your fingertips. It is even better if you are able to change leg positions while doing so.

If you are training diligently every day, you can expect this stage to take several months. If you feel like you want to take your hand off the floor, do not do so at this time. This is your ego talking and no good will come of it at this point. Stay on your fingertips longer than you think you need to.

You want to achieve consistent thirty-second holds in both a straddle and straight-body position—both on your fingertips and one arm—before advancing to the next stage. It is also a good idea to attempt to never “fall” out of the one-arm balance. This means always fighting to come back to two arms before intentionally going back to your feet. It is important to show dominance with the movement. Come down because you wanted to, not because you fell.

Next, begin making your free hand lighter by shifting even more weight to the supporting side. When your hand and fingers feel light enough, you can treat it one of two ways: move to one finger support on your free arm or hold the same position (all fingertips), where you literally feel your free arm take no weight. It is very important to be able to place all of your weight onto your supporting hand before lifting your free hand; otherwise, the lift will cause your body to fall back to center.

When you feel that your supporting arm is absolutely weightless, you can experiment with lightly tapping the floor with your free hand. Doing this will allow you to begin obtaining an actual one-arm balance for several brief moments. It is imperative that any movement with your free arm be slow and deliberate. Any jerky movements will easily throw off your balance. It is my preference to lift at the elbow, maintaining shoulder position when I tap the floor. Doing this with a straight arm is okay, but it tends to create more tension in the shoulder of your free arm. Your goal is to increase the amount of time between taps, meaning you are achieving longer one-arm holds. The taps serve as a safety net during your period of one-arm balance, as you can reach your hand back to the floor to stabilize your body if you feel you are about to fall.



Once you become proficient with the finger taps, your next step is to fully lift that arm off the floor and hold a one-arm handstand. This is easier said than done. The actual lifting of your arm must be performed in such a way that it causes no movement in the rest of your body. Your free arm must be completely relaxed and bear no weight prior to being lifted.

Though there are many ways to lift your arm, I prefer to think of it as a *développé* from ballet. Rather than lifting your whole arm at once, it is lifted in segments. This creates less impact on the rest of your body. From a one-arm handstand with fingertip support, you would first lift the elbow of your free arm, extend your forearm, and then extend your hand. While doing this, you must focus on maintaining balance with your supporting arm. If you place too much focus on lifting your free

arm, you will most likely lose your balance and fall. For this reason, I recommend you practice lifting your arm from either a pushup or chest-to-wall handstand position. This will give you an understanding of the movement before you attempt it while simultaneously trying to balance your body in a handstand position.

While first holding one-arm handstands, it is safest to keep your free hand close to the ground, that way you can always steady yourself quickly if you lose control. As you develop your awareness and hold time, you can begin moving your arm up to horizontal position and, eventually, all the way up to your body. Many people have the goal of being able to hold a basic, one-arm handstand, but that is really just the beginning. Once you can hold it, it opens a world of movement opportunities that do not exist for the majority of the world's population.

This process will test your patience. You will learn a lot about yourself, regardless of whether you achieve the skill. For the truly dedicated, the process never ends. There is always so much to work on—whether it is new skills or refinement of existing ones. Hand balancing can keep you busy for many years. The one thing you cannot avoid is putting in the work.

One last piece of advice I can give is to get a teacher and have them critique you at some point. There are many issues that you simply will not catch or be able to fix on your own. This is a skill where you would benefit greatly from another pair of eyes once in a while. Even if it is something you already know, it is a helpful to hear someone else say it.”

Note from Steven: Most of these techniques are best seen on video rather than in two-dimensional images. You can find many of the tips and techniques discussed by Yuri Marmerstein on his website, on YouTube, and in the video *Steps and Preparation to Achieving One-Arm Handstand*.

- **Website:** www.yuri-mar.com
- **YouTube:** www.youtube.com/user/bar8nmunchausen
- **Steps and Preparations for OAHS video:** www.youtube.com/watch?v=ytjIgle5CVQ

Rings Handstands – Page 1, Column 2



RINGS SHOULDER STAND – LEVEL 5

Scapular Positioning: Keep your scapulas depressed (but neither retracted or protracted) in order to have a stable base for the shoulder stand.

Body Positioning: Keep your elbows slightly in front of your body and tucked in toward your sides. Your arms should be fully curled, with your hands at shoulder height in front of your shoulders. Keep your body straight. If this makes it is easier for you to keep control, your body can be slightly hollow.

Rings handstands are located on column two on page one of the charts. First up is the *rings shoulder stand* (which can be abbreviated *R Shld Std*). This basic rings skill sets the standard for inverted positions on the rings. All of the balancing for this and subsequent rings positions will occur solely at the wrists, much like handstands on the floor, parallettes, and hand balancers. You should never stop practicing these specific body positions, as the ability to maintain them will demonstrate your overall skill and, often, your ability to apply strength.

As you begin training this skill, lower the rings as close to the ground as possible and place some padded mats or pillows in front of you in case you fall over or need to roll out. If you must use high rings, a good forward roll out of any inverted rings position is a prerequisite to learning those inverted positions. Practice rolling out at least ten times before beginning to do any support inverted skills on the rings. Before learning to fly, you must learn how to land. You will make the most progress if you have a partner or coach spotting you.

The way to roll out of a shoulder stand is to implement the fetal position, like you would to roll out of a handstand on the floor. Bring the rings in toward your chest, tense your arms so they do not flare out, and tuck your body into a ball. This allows you to rotate in a manner similar to a forward roll on the ground. At the end of the roll, you will be at the top of the pull-up position in a tuck position.

To achieve a rings shoulder stand, begin with an L-sit. This allows you to swing for momentum to get your hips up over your head. You will eventually want to learn this strict, without momentum. As your hips begin rising in the back, lean forward and bend your arms. Two things must now happen simultaneously: your hips must begin to rise up between the straps at the same time that your elbows stop bending. This transition is critical because if your arms bend too fast and leave your hips behind you end up at the bottom of the dip position, which is almost impossible for most beginners to press out from. The timing of the hip drive and the arm bend must be precise to actually get up into this position. It is in your best interest to have a solid familiarity with deep ring dips before beginning to learn this skill.

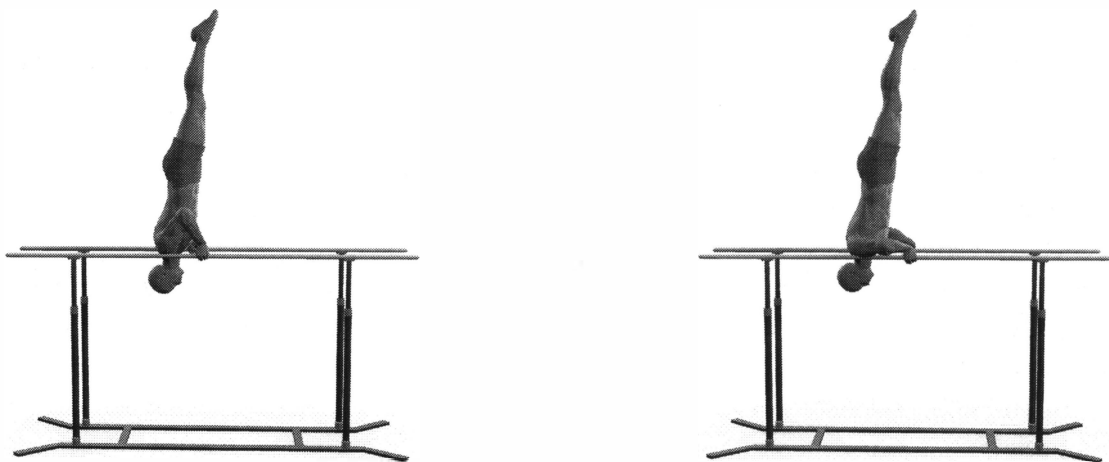
Once your hips are up and between the rings, control the shoulder stand position with your wrists. The rings should be squeezed into your chest tightly, but not so much that they tilt significantly inward. You want to pull the rings in and stabilize them so they are as much like parallettes as possible. This will allow you to execute the skill with minimal wobbling. Make sure you are gripping the rings as tightly as possible and are using your grip to control the position as you bring your feet above your head.

The pike position is recommended while learning to execute this movement. Most people will find it easier to raise their feet from the tuck position, but the tuck balance is very hard to control in the forward/backward plane with the wrists of a beginner. Piking—though slightly harder to execute initially—will allow your pelvis to act as a fulcrum for balance as you transition your legs up. Because rings are inherently unstable, adding components that help with the balance aspect will speed up your rate of progress by allowing for a higher volume of correct training.

Once you get your feet up and your body straight you should be slightly under-balanced. Your feet should not be directly overhead compared to the shoulder position, as the rings will be located slightly in front of your chest. If you are not accustomed to this, try spreading your legs out in a straddle position to allow them to hit the cables or straps. Even if you are proficient with the safety protocols, tipping over while in a handstand or shoulder stand is not conducive to proper learning.

After your legs have gone up and hit the straps, slowly bring them together. If you need more balance, you can place them on the inside of the cables at first, but your end goal is to have your feet touching. Remember, when you bring your feet together, you want to hit the proper body position (straight body) as soon as possible. Your wrists are the control mechanism, so engage them aggressively as soon as you take away the extra balance from the straps.

The key to this movement is keeping your body as still as possible while using your wrists to manipulate the movement. Because your hands are much closer to your body than in a handstand, you have the mechanical advantage through your wrists. Remember this and the rings shoulder stand will become a simple position to learn.



If you are having difficulty performing this skill on the rings, transfer it to a set of parallettes or parallel bars (shown above) if you have the appropriate equipment. The main difference with a shoulder stand on parallel bars compared to rings is your elbows will be out and wide. As you hold your body straight, your hands will control the movement in order to prevent you from tipping over or falling from the position. You can also use this method to learn the inverted position for the freestanding handstand.

RINGS STRAP HANDSTAND – LEVEL 6



Scapular Positioning: Your scapulas should be elevated maximally and slightly retracted in order to lock in the position. If your shoulder angle is not completely open (which may happen on the rings) due to a lack of strength, work on it.

Body Positioning: Your body should be completely straight—stacked through your hands, shoulders, hips, knees, and feet. Initially, you will turn the rings in and keep your arms on the straps. From there, work to turn the rings parallel and then completely out.

The best way to find the proper *rings strap handstand* position (which can be abbreviated *R Strap HS*) is through the shoulder stand. Note that the deeper your arms are bent when you begin, the harder it is to get into the full handstand position. With your legs bent and feet hooked onto the cables, push out from the bent-arm semi-handstand position. Move into the final position by using your hamstrings to bend your knees and wrap around the cable while walking your feet up the cable.

In this handstand position, look for a few key markers. Straight-body positioning is a necessity. Any bend in the elbows, however slight, makes the movement much easier to perform but emphasizes the wrong muscle set. Thus, the first thing you must do in the top position is lock your elbows out and push your shoulders out toward your ears. This centralizes the major strength component into your shoulders and the major balance component into your wrists. Shoulder strength is the base of all upper-body strength. Adaptations at the shoulders will support hand balancing aspirations as well as general strength. From a one-arm handstand to a barbell overhead press, a stronger shoulder girdle is important for all pressing movements. Press handstands, handstand pushups, planches, dips, and movements like these will also benefit from shoulder strength and coordination.

After a straight-arm handstand is achieved, your next focus should be your legs. As in the shoulder stand, instead of wrapping your legs around the outside of the cables, you want to move them to the inside. This will help promote a straight, better-aligned body, and push more of the workload to your shoulders rather than relying on the cables for balance.

These first two points should be familiar; you should have practiced both by this point. If this is the case, your primary focus will shift to the rings position, which will be a new challenge. Most beginners allow the rings to turn in while pressing. This allows the straps to ride up against your arm, which reduces the difficulty

of the handstand. While this helps beginners get their feet to the top, it actually makes the movement more difficult once they get there. Thus, it is important that you learn to turn the rings out while pressing, much like the standard support position. At first, it will be difficult to force your arms off the straps. However, doing so will lead to greater balance and strength adaptations, which will be of great benefit in the long run. You will have to work toward this progressively, with the intermediate aim of having the rings reach parallel to one another.

The goal that most gymnastics coaches emphasize is to start to turn the rings out while in a handstand, from parallel to forty-five degrees past the parallel rings position. This provides an optimal amount of control and sets up large rings swinging moves like giants. These and similar moves are beyond the scope of this book, but you are encouraged to work with the rings turned out to a parallel position at minimum. This will afford you more control and the additional benefits of the stabilization factors.

RINGS HANDSTAND – LEVEL 7



As you can see, the first image looks like straight body positioning until it is compared to the second image.

Scapular Positioning: As you might expect, your scapulas should be elevated maximally and retracted slightly in order to lock in the position. Even if you can obtain correct scapular positioning with the *rings strap handstand* you will probably regress a bit to bent arms and decreased scapular elevation once you progress to the *freestanding rings handstand*. Take care to correct this.

Body Positioning: Your body should be completely straight—stacked through your hands, shoulders, hips, knees, and feet. Initially, turn the rings in and keep your arms on the straps. From there, work to turn the rings parallel and then completely out. Much like with scapular positioning, you will regress and the rings will begin to turn in. Work on turning them back out and be sure to correctly align the handstand. It may be helpful to film yourself doing this so you can review and make corrections as needed.

The *rings handstand* (which can be abbreviated *R HS*) is an extension of the rings strap handstand, with two new goals. Instead of pressing into a shoulder stand and inching your way up to the top position, it is best to attempt to press into the full handstand position. Even if you do not hit it on the press alone, you will be

working your way up from a higher start position and reinforcing a harder press until you can achieve the full handstand position. Your second goal is actually more important: as you work to improve this top position of the handstand, aim to use the straps for assistance less and less.

As in the shoulder stand press, aim for a nice pike or straddle body position in order to offer hip control during your ascent. Modulate the forces accordingly to get your body into the correct position as soon as technically feasible, as you would in the kick-to-handstand position on the floor. Do you see how skills you have previously acquired begin to work together as you move into more advanced levels?

Remember, balance and control the movement with your wrists, especially when you are near the top position. Use the cables for assistance when you must, but try to cut down on your use of them. As you progress, you may only need to tap the cables with the inside of your toes rather than wrapping your legs around them. The fewer progressions you make, the more consistent the position. The more consistent the position, the faster you will progress.

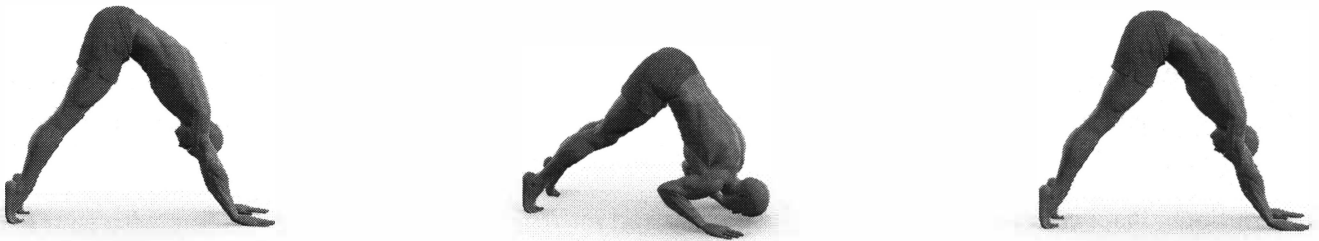
As soon as you reach the rings handstand position, make sure to turn the rings out and make an effort to open up your shoulders, and squeeze your abdominals and glutes. Performing a handstand on the rings will tempt you to arch your back significantly more than performing a handstand on the floor. Obtaining a straight-body position is quite difficult, requiring impressive shoulder and core strength, as well as patience and practice.

This is an A-level skill in the Gymnastics Code of Points.

Handstand Pushups – Page 1, Column 3

The key to the handstand pushup series is to emphasize good body positions. If you are wobbly or have poor body position, it is stunting your development.

PIKE HEADSTAND PUSHUP – LEVEL 1

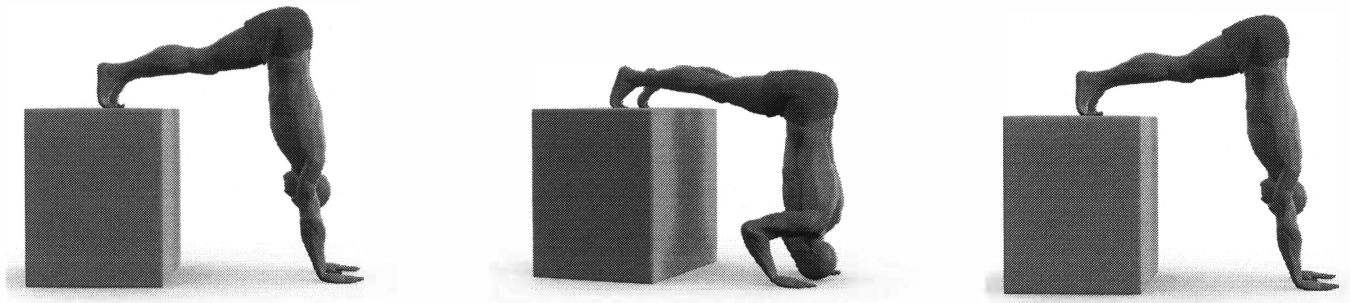


Scapular Positioning: Begin with your scapulas elevated. As your head comes toward the ground, they will naturally begin to depress. Once your head touches the ground and you start pushing back up, seek to end with your scapulas elevated.

Technique: Place your hands and feet on the ground and move into the pike starting position. Bend your arms and place as much weight as possible over your hands. As you bend your arms, be sure to tuck your elbows in line with your body, rather than flaring them out to the sides. Keep your head in line and allow it to touch the ground. Once it touches the ground, repeat the same process backward and push out to the starting position.

The key to proper development of the *pike headstand pushup* (which can be abbreviated *Pike HeSPU*) is to add as much of your weight as possible onto your hands without toppling over. This will bias strength to your anterior shoulders, triceps, and the upper portion of your chest. It is important to keep your shoulder angle as open as possible. Think of it in terms of reaching up toward the sky, only upside down.

Do not allow the elbows to flare outward during the pressing phase. Your upper arm should remain parallel with your body (that is, your elbows should stay glued to the imaginary plane with your sides). If you allow your elbows to flare the movement will feel substantially easier, but it removes your forward-backward stability and hinders the development of advanced skills. It is especially easy for your elbows to flare when you are fatigued, so be mindful.

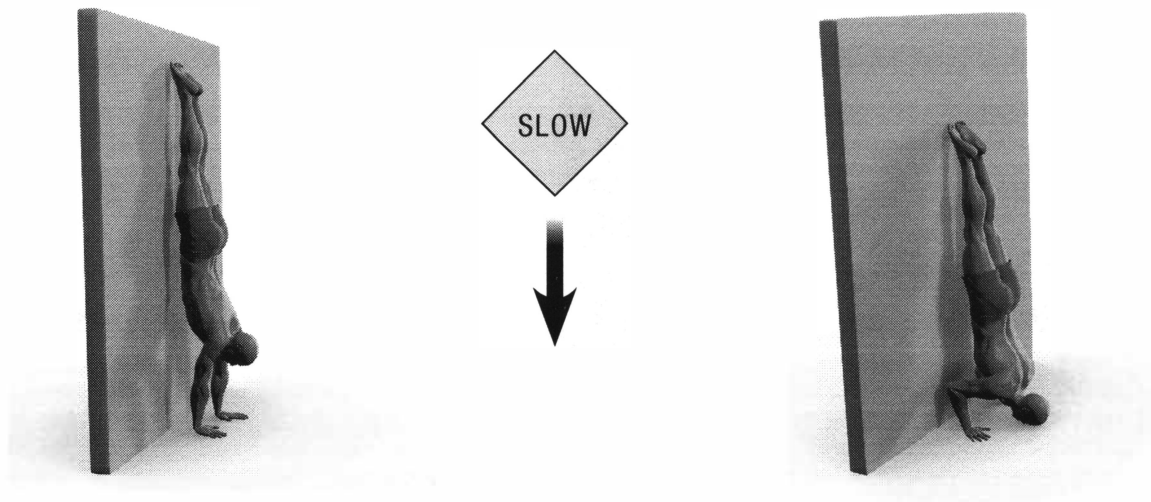
BOX HEADSTAND PUSHUP – LEVEL 2

Scapular Positioning: Begin with your scapulas elevated. As your head comes toward the ground, they will naturally begin to depress. Once your head touches the ground and you start pushing back up, seek to end with your scapulas elevated.

Technique: Place your hands and feet on the ground and move into the pike starting position, with your feet elevated on a block, box, chair, counter, or any other sturdy surface. Bend your arms and place as much weight as possible over your hands. As you bend your arms, keep your elbows tucked in (rather than flaring them out to the sides). Keep your head in line and allow it to touch the ground. Once it touches the ground, repeat the same process backward and push out to the starting position.

A *box headstand pushup* (which can be abbreviated Box HeSPU) utilizes boxes of varying heights to increase the bias of weight onto your arms and the openness of the shoulder angle. The remaining execution of this movement mirrors a standard headstand pushup.

While performing this movement, your body will have a tendency to keel over frontward if you lack adequate strength in your shoulders or triceps. Conversely, if you are slightly under-balanced, your body will want to push more weight toward your feet to alleviate weight on your arms. If possible, you should not allow either of these scenarios to occur. Additionally, do not allow your head to come out too much, as this will cause your back to arch, creating further issues.

WALL HEADSTAND PUSHUP ECCENTRIC – LEVEL 3

Scapular Positioning: Begin with your scapulas elevated. As your head comes toward the ground, they will naturally begin to depress and come forward as your elbows move in that direction.

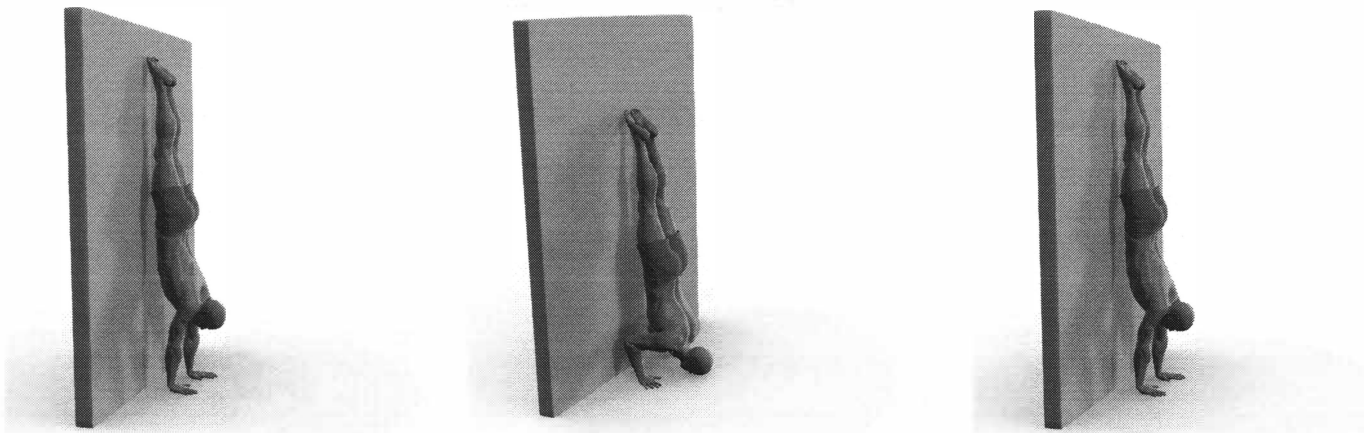
Technique: Begin in a wall handstand position, with your body completely straight and your feet barely touching the wall. Initiate the movement as illustrated above by allowing your shoulder angle to close while bending at the elbow. Slowly lower to the ground in a uniform movement. Make sure to keep your body straight as your head descends toward the ground. Do not arch.

The *wall headstand pushup eccentric* movement (which can be abbreviated *Wall HeSPU Eccen.*) is a step up from box headstand pushups. With this movement, you are controlling your entire body weight, but still receive assistance from the wall as a balance component.

To emphasize proper body positioning, use the stomach-to-the-wall position that you would use for a handstand. If you are not yet comfortable in this position, the back-to-the-wall variation can be used, but this can cause your back to arch since your heels are against the wall. Keep your hands as close to the wall as possible to avoid further arching when you descend.

Since this is an intermediate eccentric movement between the piked box headstand pushup and full wall headstand pushup, use a 5-10s eccentric phase. Your goal while performing the movement should be control and consistency. Avoid flaring your elbows.

WALL HEADSTAND PUSHUP – LEVEL 4



Scapular Positioning: Begin with your scapulas elevated. As your head comes toward the ground, they will naturally begin to depress and come forward as your elbows move in that direction. Once your head touches the ground and you start pushing back up, seek to end with your scapulas elevated.

Technique: Begin in a wall handstand position, with your body completely straight and your feet barely touching the wall. Initiate the movement as illustrated above by allowing your shoulder angle to close while bending at the elbow. Slowly lower to the ground in a uniform movement. Make sure to keep your body straight as your head descends toward the ground. Do not arch. Once your head lightly touches the ground, push back up to the starting position. Push through your triceps and shoulders, eventually covering your shoulders like earmuffs.

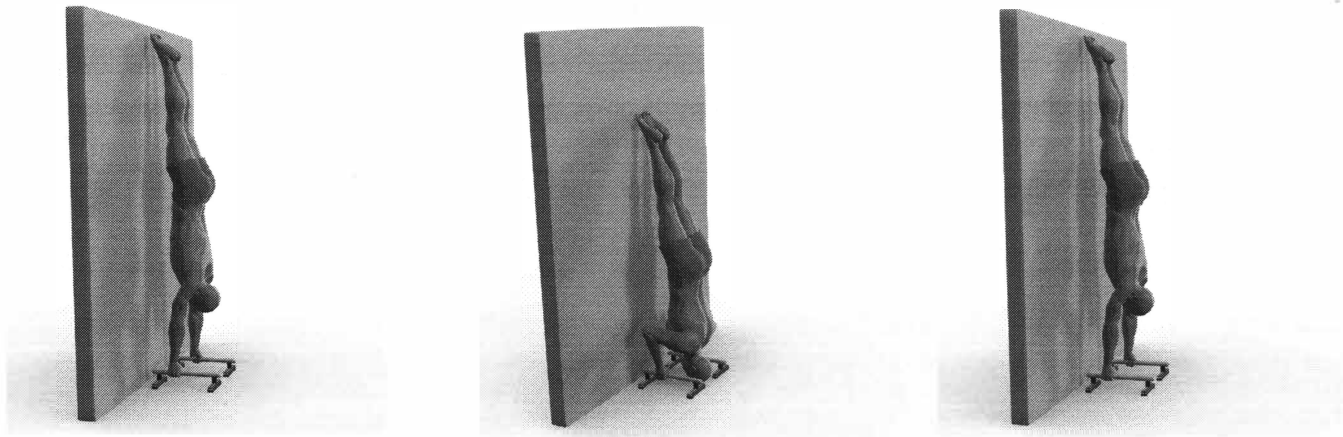
This is what most people think of when they hear the term “handstand pushups.” While *wall headstand pushups* (which can be abbreviated *Wall HeSPU*) are not true handstand pushups (because the range of motion is stopped by your head touching the floor), they are still a feat of overhead pressing strength and body control.

The key to this movement is the same as the eccentric portions of the movement: control and maintaining correct body positioning. Your goal should be to build up awareness and strength in your primary movers, not obtaining as many repetitions as possible each set.

Arching of the back is typically a huge problem with headstand pushups, and it is multifaceted. Fatigue is the biggest culprit. As your body fatigues, it is tempting—almost natural—to do what is necessary to bring in other muscles to aid with the movement. When this happens, incorrect neural strength patterns are established. This should be avoided.

Handstand pushups and their variations are built through proper position, control, and strength through the shoulders. When you arch, you let the trapezius and pectoralis muscles become prime movers as the shoulder angle closes. This not only emphasizes incorrect neural patterns, but builds general strength in the wrong muscles. Additionally, arching makes the body less aware of its position in space as tension is lost through the core and hips.

WALL HANDSTAND PUSHUP – LEVEL 5



Scapular Positioning: Begin with your scapulas elevated. As your head comes toward the ground, they will naturally begin to depress and come forward as your elbows move in that direction. Allow this to happen all the way through to the bottom. Your scapulas will then be in a neutral, depressed position. Once your head touches the ground and you start pushing back up, seek to end with your scapulas elevated.

Technique: Begin in a wall handstand position, with your body completely straight, your feet barely touching the wall, and your hands raised on parallettes or other elevated materials. Initiate the movement illustrated above by allowing your shoulder angle to close while bending at the elbow. Slowly lower to the ground in a uniform movement. Make sure to keep your body as straight as possible as your head descends toward the ground. Do not arch. Once your head lightly touches the ground, push back up to the starting position. Focus on pushing through your triceps and shoulders, eventually covering your shoulders like earmuffs.

Wall handstand pushups (which can be abbreviated *Wall HSPU*) require placing your hands on a raised surface to fully hit the bottom of the movement. This position creates an extreme mechanical disadvantage, as your shoulder muscles and especially your triceps end up significantly lengthened. Keep your elbows glued to your side; do not let them flare out.

You can use almost anything to raise your hands, but taking safety and consistency into consideration. Most people default to parallettes, but other solutions could include mats or panel mats (if you are in a gymnastics gym). You can also use wood blocks, boxes, or chairs, but this is more dangerous. Whatever you do, do it safely, and be consistent.

Perform this movement with your body against the wall. Given the elevated nature of this movement, it is understandable to use back-to-the-wall positioning because it is easier to get down safely, especially as a beginner. You should also practice how to pirouette or roll out of movements to save your body if you begin to fall.

The key to wall handstand pushups is to maintain full tension in your shoulders and triceps while in the bottom of the movement. If you relax when you reach the bottom, it will not be easy to re-create tension while holding the position. Strength-wise, this movement is quite a jump from headstand pushups. Many people are not able to perform the full movement initially. To combat this, you have two options. The first

(and preferred) is the use of negatives/eccentrics. If you cannot press out of the bottom of this movement, lower yourself as slowly as possible until you can safely exit the movement. This will allow you to gain strength throughout your full range of motion. The second option is to place your head above an elevated surface that is the right height to allow you to go as deep as you can handle without going any deeper. This will allow both lowering and pressing back up. Because these will be partial range of motion movements, you must increase the height of the surface to deepen your range of motion as you are able, until the full movement is obtained.

FREESTANDING HEADSTAND PUSHUP – LEVEL 6



Scapular Positioning: Begin with your scapulas elevated. As your head comes toward the ground, they will naturally begin to depress and come forward as your elbows move in that direction. Allow this to happen all the way through to the bottom. Your scapulas will then be in a neutral, depressed position. Once your head touches the ground and you start pushing back up. Seek to end with your scapulas elevated.

Technique: Begin in a handstand position, with your body completely straight. Initiate the movement illustrated above by allowing your shoulder angle to close while bending at the elbow. Slowly lower to the ground in a uniform movement. Make sure to keep your body straight as your head descends toward the ground. Do not arch. Once your head lightly touches the ground, push back up to the starting position. Focus on pushing through your triceps and shoulders, eventually covering your shoulders like earmuffs. End with your body completely straight.

The next phase of the progression is the *freestanding headstand pushup* (which can be abbreviated *Free HeSPU*). You will have issues if you have been working handstand pushups without the accompanying handstand holds, since you must be strong with both of these to work Free HeSPU's. Having a sense for both the still-hold and moving aspects of the handstand is critical in order to progress with freestanding handstand pushups. If this is a problem, take a step back and practice handstands; they are classified as skill work and can be practiced every day if necessary. You should be able to bring up your sense of balance very quickly if you have emphasized correct body positions all along. Technical considerations of this skill are the same as the previous variations. Correct body alignment continues to be vital.

The difficulty of this skill lies in balancing the dynamic movement. If your shoulder muscles and triceps are not strong enough to handle the small corrections that must be made during the movement, you will tip over. Even if the movement is failed, it can still be completed (though poorly) by losing core tension and arching your back in the movement. Arching your back in the movement compensates for a lack of shoulder and triceps strength in an attempt to add chest and trapezius strength to the movement. You want to avoid this. Maintaining strict body positioning pays dividends in the long run.

Along the same vein, if you flare your elbows you do not have good forward and backward control. If you find yourself guilty of flared elbows often, make a stronger effort to keep your elbows in during all movements. You may need to drop a progression or two until you can perform the movement without flaring your elbows.

You also do not want to put weight on your head when you touch the ground. It does stabilize the headstand position before pushing out, but it ignores the need for proper control near the bottom of the